Online version

Yearly follow-up during your PhD studies

The yearly follow-up is a chance to review progress, update the study and research plans, and discuss supervision openly. The process combines the Individual Study Plan (ISP) with a Thesis Follow-Up Committee (TFC).

At the start of the PhD

Apply for the study right via Studieinfo.fi.

After admission, update the ISP within the first three months using the plan submitted with the doctoral-study application.

Every doctoral researcher has at least two supervisors. One is the responsible supervisor and must be a docent or have equivalent qualifications. See section 4.4 of the Regulation on Doctoral Studies.

Within the same first three months:

- recruit two TFC members together with the supervisor(s); and
- arrange the first TFC meeting.

The yearly cycle

The ISP must be updated once a year, normally at the end of the autumn semester unless the doctoral programme decides otherwise. The responsible supervisor also holds a follow-up and development meeting with the doctoral researcher at least once a year. See section 4.3 of the Regulation on Doctoral Studies.

The TFC meets every year until the thesis defence. The doctoral researcher organises the meetings.

The recommended committee has two members, internal or external to Åbo Akademi University, in addition to the supervisor(s). Its role is to provide scientific and practical advice and to help identify problems early. The study plan or research plan can be updated after the discussion.

If a problem with the research or supervision arises between meetings, the doctoral researcher can contact the TFC members or the ombudsperson. The researcher must have an opportunity to speak with the TFC in confidence.

Before each TFC meeting

At least one week before the meeting:

- update the ISP, including the research plan;
- send the updated ISP to the TFC and supervisors; and
- circulate the agenda and any other material.

During the meeting

Allow up to **90 minutes**.

1. **Researcher presentation and discussion — up to 60 minutes.** Cover the doctoral training plan and the main points needed to judge progress toward graduation:
   - completed and planned courses;
   - scientific progress;
   - publication plan;
   - funding plan; and
   - expected graduation date.
2. **Committee feedback.** Discuss the graduation plan, research plan, and presentation.
3. **Confidential discussion with the supervisor(s) — 10–15 minutes.** The doctoral researcher leaves the room so the committee and supervisor(s) can discuss any concerns.
4. **Confidential discussion with the doctoral researcher — final 10 minutes.** The supervisor(s) leave so the doctoral researcher can raise supervision-related questions or concerns directly with the committee.

After the meeting

Within one week, write short minutes, share them with the participants, make any final changes to the ISP, and submit the updated ISP to the graduate school.

Quick checklist

First three months

☐ Update the ISP
☐ Recruit two TFC members with the supervisor(s)
☐ Arrange the first TFC meeting

Before each yearly meeting

☐ Update the ISP and research plan
☐ Send them to the TFC and supervisor(s) at least one week in advance
☐ Circulate the agenda and supporting material

During each meeting

☐ Review graduation requirements and target date
☐ Review courses and scientific progress
☐ Review the publication plan
☐ Review the funding plan
☐ Hold the confidential discussion without the doctoral researcher
☐ Hold the confidential discussion without the supervisor(s)

Useful resource

- 📝 Skills and Competencies (DOCX)

Last updated: 28 September 2026